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First off, I should say I'm not a hardcore gamer, and I've never played Guitar Hero or any other game designed to delude you into thinking that your plastic, guitar-shaped controller is a guitar, and that you're as talented as Joe Satriani (or whoever your musician God is).

I remember telling someone, "No, you're not playing guitar, you're just rather good at tapping coloured buttons in something akin to a whack-a-mole game. Monkeys have been known to do the same for treats..."

As for my guitar skills? I suck, which is why I called for a copy of Rocksmith 2014 to test its claim of being "the fastest way to learn guitar".

I got a Steam code for the game from Ubisoft, some codes for DLCs (Downloadable Content) and installed it to find out that you need something called a 'Real Tone Cable' to connect your guitar. Bummer! Many months later, I was reminded about the game and bought the cable.

I fired up the game, went through the rather boring setup process of calibration and tuning (targeted at absolute beginners). I skipped whatever was skippable and dove straight into the "Learn a song" option. Big mistake.

This game is designed for those who've played games like Guitar Hero before. You still get visuals that are designed to tell

you what to press when, except here it's one of the strings on your actual guitar at a specific fret, instead of a plastic button. When a chord is displayed, the game even tries to tell you which finger to place where in order to play it correctly. So I had to go back and patiently sit through the tutorials to understand the controls. Lesson learnt.

I'd never played Def Leppard's *Pour Some Sugar On Me* before, or even tried to. However, just by repeatedly playing it in Rocksmith 2014 (first with a rhythm guitar profile and then with a lead guitar profile) for 2-3 days (a couple of hours each day), I now play the song well enough to perform it on stage, if needed.

Now the pace of learning will be different for every person, and while many of you will be able to learn songs much faster, some might take a bit longer. But the fact of the matter is, this game really does teach you how to play a few popular songs, and does it pretty quickly. It also adapts to your skill level automatically, however you can also manually force it to the level of difficulty you want.



Verdict

Is it better than a human guitar teacher showing you the ropes and teaching and correcting your techniques? Not at all. In fact, you're likely to pick up some bad habits. Plus, the game is too "precise". An example of this is when the game expects you to play quick chords or notes (say, A then B), it expects you to pick each note with your plectrum, whereas those used to playing guitar will take the shortcut of sliding up to B from A. If you do that though, the game counts it as a "Miss" despite both notes sounding clear.

Is there a simpler and cheaper way to learn the basics of guitar? Not at all. Rocksmith 2014 makes learning guitar a challenge, with competitive scoring. So, even if it's just to beat a friend's score, more kids will learn to actually play a guitar rather than by tapping away idiotically at those stupid plastic controllers, and for that it gets my unequivocal support.

I've also recently discovered guitarists on our forum who play Rocksmith 2014. Go to <http://dgit.in/1tU52xG> to see what they're upto.

MOAR!

Developer: Ubisoft San Francisco

Genre: Music video game

Price: ₹2,999 (Xbox 360, PS3) + ₹499 cable; ₹2,999 (PC - cable included)

Publisher: Activision